

# Wildfire Smoke: breathe safe, help others

---

Wildfire smoke carries tiny particles that enter your lungs and bloodstream. Much smoke exposure can be reduced. The two things that matter most: **stay aware of air quality** and **reduce smoke exposure indoors and out**.

## MEDICAL EMERGENCY

### Smoke can trigger life-threatening reactions

Call your local emergency number **immediately** if someone has chest pain, severe shortness of breath, confusion, or lips/fingernails turning blue. People with asthma or COPD should follow their emergency action plan and seek care if rescue inhalers do not help.

## Air Quality Index — know the colors

---

The AQI tells you how dangerous the air is right now. Check an official local air-quality source when available, such as **AirNow.gov** in the U.S., your national/regional environment agency, or a trusted local weather alert service.

### 0–50 GREEN

#### Good

Air quality is fine. Normal activities are safe for most people.

### 51–100 YELLOW

#### Moderate

People unusually sensitive to smoke, including children, older adults, and people with asthma/COPD or heart disease, should consider reducing prolonged outdoor exertion.

### 101–150 ORANGE

#### Unhealthy for sensitive groups

Sensitive groups should avoid prolonged or heavy outdoor exertion; everyone else should consider reducing it, especially if symptoms appear.

### 151–200 RED

#### Unhealthy

Everyone should avoid prolonged exertion outdoors. Sensitive groups should stay inside.

201–300 **PURPLE**

### Very unhealthy

Everyone should reduce activity, stay indoors in cleaner air if possible, and keep windows closed unless indoor heat creates a bigger immediate danger.

301+ **MAROON**

### Hazardous

Emergency conditions. Avoid outdoor exertion. If you must go out and can wear one safely, use a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator.

## Who is most at risk?

---

- Children and teenagers (lungs still developing)
- Adults 65 and older
- Pregnant people
- People with asthma, COPD, or other lung diseases
- People with heart disease or diabetes
- Outdoor workers
- People experiencing homelessness or without reliable shelter

## Protect yourself and others

---

- 1 **Check the AQI every morning** during wildfire season. Set alerts on AirNow or your weather app.
- 2 **Stay indoors in cleaner air** with windows and doors closed when smoke is unhealthy, unless indoor heat or another hazard makes that unsafe.
- 3 **Create a clean-air room.** Choose an interior room with few windows. Run an air purifier continuously. Avoid candles, frying, vacuuming, or gas stoves without ventilation.
- 4 **Wear a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator** if you must go outside in unhealthy smoke and can wear one safely. Cloth masks do not reliably block PM2.5; respirators may not fit infants/young children and may be difficult for some people with breathing conditions.
- 5 **Consider a Corsi-Rosenthal box.** This DIY air cleaner uses a box fan and MERV-13 or better filters and can substantially reduce indoor particle levels when built and used correctly. Follow current build and electrical-safety guidance; use newer, safety-certified fans where possible; and do not block exits or create trip hazards.
- 6 **Check on vulnerable neighbors daily.** Offer masks, a ride to a clean-air shelter, or help running a filter.
- 7 **Reduce or cancel outdoor events** when AQI is over 150.

## For community organizers

---

### ACTION CHECKLIST

- Identify or coordinate **clean-air spaces** with HEPA filtration, safe DIY air cleaners, or other verified filtration.
- **Distribute well-fitting respirators** to outdoor workers and unhoused neighbors, with fit/use caveats and local worker-safety guidance.
- Share AQI alerts via text, social media, and local networks.
- Reschedule outdoor community events when AQI > 150.
- Partner with local libraries, community centers, and faith groups to extend shelter hours.

## When to seek medical help

---

- Difficulty breathing or shortness of breath
- Persistent cough, especially with phlegm or blood
- Chest pain or tightness
- Wheezing that does not improve with medication
- Dizziness or confusion
- Palpitations or irregular heartbeat

## Key resources

---

- **AirNow.gov** — Real-time AQI and fire maps (U.S.)
- **Fire and Smoke Map** — [fire.airnow.gov](https://fire.airnow.gov)
- **EPA Wildfire Smoke Guide** — [epa.gov/pm-pollution/wildfire-smoke-guide-factsheets](https://epa.gov/pm-pollution/wildfire-smoke-guide-factsheets)
- **Corsi-Rosenthal Box build guides** — [cleanaircrew.org](https://cleanaircrew.org)
- **Emergency** — 911 (U.S./Canada), 112 (Europe), 999 (UK)

---

### Sources include:

- AirNow — wildfire smoke and air quality information.
- U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) — wildfire smoke and health guidance.
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — wildfire smoke and health.
- U.S. National Weather Service — wildfire safety.
- Published research and public guidance on DIY air filtration; verify device-building instructions against current safety guidance before use.

This guide is for educational purposes and does not replace professional medical advice. In an emergency, call your local emergency number.